Though Shah Jahan was his father's preferred successor—indeed, his name meant "King of the World"—the prince still found it necessary to wrench control of the empire from his male family members after the death of his royal father. Once the deed had been done, Jahan and Mahal set to the administration of the realm in earnest. Like his predecessors, Shah Jahan was a devout Muslim who believed in the existence of one God, Allah. Despite his personal ties to Islam, however, Shah Jahan wanted to rule over a kingdom in which he was not only respected but loved by his people. To that end, he declared that Hindus and Muslims were equal in the Mughal Empire, and he even introduced a brand-new language—Hindavi, also known as Hindustani—to his courts and official offices. A mixture of Sanskrit and Persian, Hindavi allowed members of both religions to converse more easily. This would eventually develop into the modern Hindi and Urdu languages.

The Shah's happiness did not last forever as his favorite empress would not live long past the delivery of her 14th child. As she succumbed to complications from the birth, Shah Jahan promised to build her the most beautiful mausoleum in all creation. She died in 1631, at the age of 38, and left her husband grieving terribly.

According to the famous story, "The king cried out with grief like an ocean raging with storm. He put aside his royal robes and for the whole week afterward, his majesty did not appear in public, nor transact any affairs of state. From constant weeping, he was forced to use spectacles and his hair turned gray."

Six months after his most beloved wife's passing, Shah Jahan ordered a stunning new building to be constructed for Mumtaz Mahal. Like the beautiful waterworks and temples commissioned by his great-grandfather and grandfather, Akbar the Great, the mausoleum was to be immaculate and grand. To meet his exacting taste, however, it and all other palaces under his construction were to be pieced together with only the finest of white marble. The foundations for this great work were laid within sight of his palace in Agra.

For 11 years, white marble was mined in Rajasthan, while red sandstone was shipped from Delhi to meet the demands of the giant tomb. The supplies were brought into Agra on a single-purpose, 16-kilometer (10-mile) ramp, while around the budding tomb, a whole city sprouted to house the 20,000 laborers and artisans working on the project. By 1643, the main